

ARTS & CULTURE



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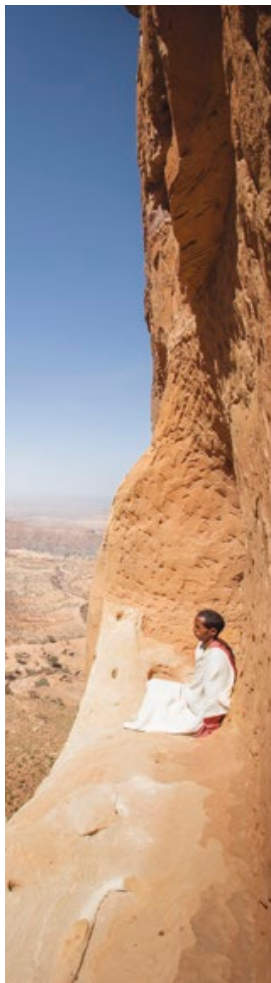
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INTRODUCTION

Last year, while taking our children on their first foray into Africa we visited Marrakesh in Morocco. On our first evening we walked into the Djemaa el-Fna (page 16), the city's world famous open square. It was like walking into another world. The smoke and smells from food stalls, the sound of drummers and the clamour of people shouting, singing and hawking their wares. Everyone's eyes were out on stalks, senses in overdrive. I had been worried it would be too much, but the kids asked to go again the following night. One of the most memorable moments I've had travelling cost nothing beyond the gumption to walk into the square that night.

The monetary value implied in the term *free* can misrepresent what's on offer within these pages. The quality of an experience, after all, is not attached to a price tag. Many of the suggestions here involve unearthing the world's secret wonders, whether that's swimming around Sydney's ocean pools (page 267) or strolling the tombs and monuments of Delhi's Lodi Gardens (page 37). Walkers tackling the great tracks of New Zealand (page 260) will find themselves close to the soul of those beautiful islands.

For many of us, when we take our first steps travelling free things are not only appealing but essential if we're to make our backpacking days last as long as possible. And it's not just formative forays - many unforgettable blasts of freedom and discovery tend to be budget affairs. You quickly realise that

cheap can mean much, much better. No Roman dinner will ever match the bread and cheese picnic in Villa Celimontana, a short walk from the Colosseum, on my first visit to the Eternal City. And if we're talking life lessons, there are few better insights into the human condition than sharing a dorm room with a dozen others from around the world.

Nations all around the world recognise the value of making the wonders under their stewardship accessible. 5000 years of Chinese history? Free (National Museum of China, page 28). 19 museums and galleries in Washington DC? Free (Smithsonian Institution, page 242). Britain's national parks? All free. Donations always welcome, of course. And if you want to experience all those popular places at their best then get up early and get there before the crowds arrive. The priceless calm of early mornings doesn't come with a price tag either, by the way.

It's an exaggeration to say that everything good is free, so you'll find plenty of excellent value cheap things to experience throughout this book. Dip into your spare change for classy street food like a *choripán* (chorizo sandwich) in Buenos Aires (page 277), the best views of Hong Kong's skyline from the Star Ferry (page 48) and a Boston brewery tour (page 179). Great memories, a happier you and a grateful wallet; one glance through these pages and you may never aspire to the indulgences of top-end travel again.

Tom Hall



CAPE TOWN

South Africa's proudly multicultural Mother City sits between the Rainbow Nation's most iconic natural feature, Table Mountain, and the appropriately named Cape of Good Hope. Both mountain and ocean offer myriad opportunities for free recreation, and Cape Town comes to the party with countless cool activities and attractions.



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FESTIVALS & EVENTS

01 District Six

Once a tight-knit community historically comprised of freed slaves, artisans, labourers and immigrants, District Six was torn apart under apartheid. By 1966 it was a white area; 60,000 occupants had been evicted and their homes bulldozed. You can independently explore the reclaimed streets, but don't miss the **District Six Museum** (districtsix.co.za; 25a Buitenkant St; 9am-4pm Mon-Sat; R30), which also runs **Sunset Walking Tours** (5.50pm spring-summer; R100) led by ex-residents.

02 Free diamond tour

South Africa has been synonymous with diamonds since the 1840s, as the **Cape Town Diamond Museum** (capetowndiamondmuseum.org; Clock Tower, Level 1, Waterfront; 9am-9pm; R50) explains. Entry usually costs, but download a voucher from **Shimansky** (shimansky.com) to score a free tour. You even get a *gratis* glass of South African wine as you're walked through the cutting factory, manufacturing workshop, and diamond and tanzanite showroom. Exit through the gift shop...

03 St George's Cathedral

Even if a guided trip to the jail that once held Mandela and other political prisoners, **Robben Island** (robben-island.org.za; R300) is beyond your budget, don't miss the 'People's Cathedral', where Archbishop Desmond Tutu led a dignified decades-long struggle against apartheid. The cathedral choir gives occasional free performances. The main service

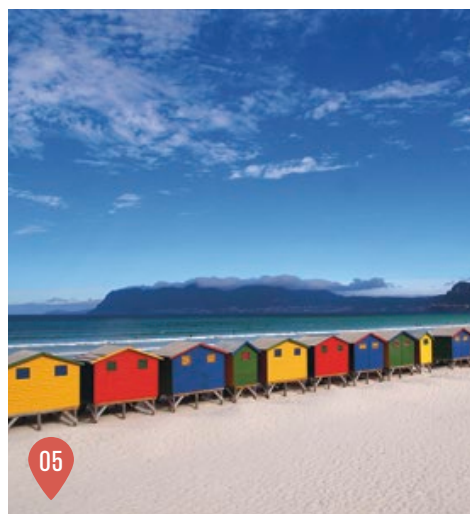
takes place at 9.30am on Sundays, but visitors are always welcome. Tours of the Victorian-style church are also available. sgcathedral.co.za; 5 Wale St; free.

04 Whatiftheworld Gallery

Occupying an ubercool space in a decommissioned Woodstock synagogue, this forward-facing gallery has provided hanging space for contemporary Southern African artists since 2008. Many of the young artists originally championed have since shaped the country's artistic landscape, but there's always a new wave coming though. Check the website for exhibitions. whatiftheworld.com; 1 Argyle St, Woodstock; 10am-5pm Tue-Fri, 10am-2pm Sat; free.

05 Beach life

Cape Town's beautiful beaches are legendary. **Camps Bay** (5a) and **Clifton** (5b) are the trendy city options; Atlantic-facing **Llandudno** (5c) is for surfers; remote **Sandy Bay** (5d) for nudists;



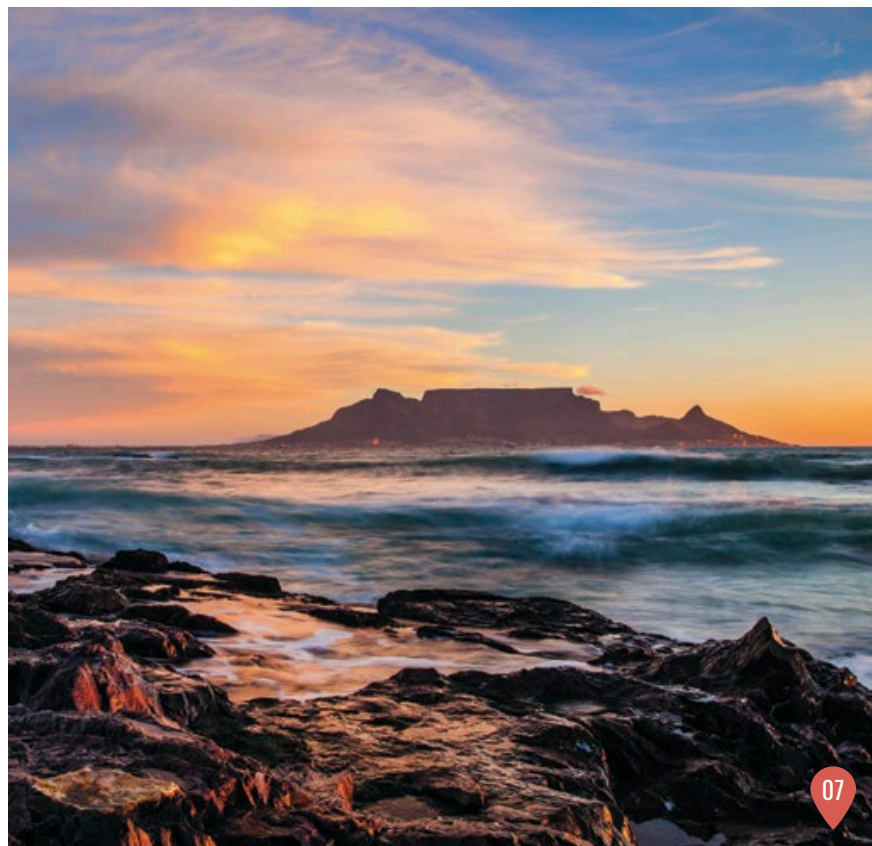
THE LOCAL'S VIEW

"Cape Town's shops and premier art galleries stay open late on the first Thursday of the month, which is cool. Picnics on Signal Hill are sensational in summer, when you can also score free concerts in De Waal Park on Sunday afternoons. I'm from Hout Bay, though, and most sunny Sundays I hit the market by the harbour (after saying 'hi' to Bob, the resident seal), where there's great food, a bar and live music. Later, I might enjoy a bottle of wine on the beach or head to Noordhoek Farm Village (noordhoekvillage.co.za) to hear more live music." – Katie Owens, company director.





sheltered **False Bay's Muizenberg** (5e) and **St James** (5f) are family friendly, with water warmed by Indian Ocean currents. All are free, except Simons Town's **Boulders Beach** (5g; 8am-6.30pm, longer in Dec-Jan; R60) with its 3000 endangered African penguins.



06 Bo-Kaap
On the side of Signal Hill, Bo-Kaap, the former Malay Quarter, is famous for its streetscapes, mosques and cuisine-based tourism. Wander freely around the streets, visit the cheap **Bo-Kaap Museum** (6a; bokaap.co.za/museum; 71 Wale St; 10am-5pm Mon-Sat; R20) or do a **cooking course/tour** (bokaapcookingtour.co.za; R700, including dinner). Nearby is **Long St** (6b), home of the city's underground entertainment scene, alongside second-hand bookshops and boho boutiques.

07 Howl at the lion
Table Mountain National Park (7a) has hundreds of trails, wending around the Twelve Apostles, Devil's Peak, Signal Hill and Table Mountain. Most are free-access, but there are four pay points. Various routes scale the vertical kilometre to Devil's Peak, but if you're here during a full moon, join locals trekking with beers to **Lion's Head** (7b) to watch moonrise over the Hottentots Holland Mountains.



08 Sea Point promenade
Loved by everyone from runners and skaters to hand-holding couples and kids, this 11km-long, wave-splattered, careless and car-free coastal stretch is full of playgrounds and amazing outdoor artwork. You can swim for free in the wild Atlantic, or seek sanctuary in one of the world's finest public pools, the open-air **Sea Point Pavilion** (www.capetown.gov.za; 7am-7pm summer, 9am-5pm winter;

IZIKO MUSEUMS

The Iziko Museums of South Africa (iziko.org.za) is an 11-strong collection of Cape Town's top museums and attractions, including the Bo-Kaap Museum, the South African National Gallery (Government Ave, Company's Garden; 10am-5pm), South African Museum and Planetarium (25 Queen Victoria St; 10am-5pm), Maritime Centre (Union-Castle House, Dock Rd, V&A Waterfront; 10am-5pm) and Groot Constantia Manor House (Groot Constantia Estate; 10am-5pm), the oldest wine-producing estate in the country. These museums typically charge about R30, but for eight or nine days each year, typically public holidays, they all throw their doors open for free. Check the website for up-to-date details.



R21) with diving boards, splash puddles and two Olympic-size lap pools.

09 Victoria & Alfred Waterfront

A former wharf transformed into a swanky waterfront entertainment, eating and shopping arena, the V&A offers everything from free wi-fi to meetings with freedom fighters Nelson Mandela and Desmond Tutu – albeit in bronze form. Selfie-snappers shouldn't pose too long next to the seals, though – they're the real deal. Street performers provide entertainment, and free events take place year-round. *Robben Island tours depart here.* waterfront.co.za; 9am-9pm; free.

10 Going downtown

Visiting a Township is an essential Cape Town experience; combine it with a budget feed at **Mzoli's** (10a; *Gugulethu*; 9am-6pm; meals R50-100). Buy meat at this Gugs butcher and get it cooked on a traditional *braai* (barbecue), while supping beer and bouncing to Kwaito beats. Excellent tours (laurastownshiptours.co.za; R400) can be done, and shack accommodation is available at **Vicky's**

B&B (10b; *Khayelitsha Township*), complete with Xhosa-style home cooking.

11 Wine tasting

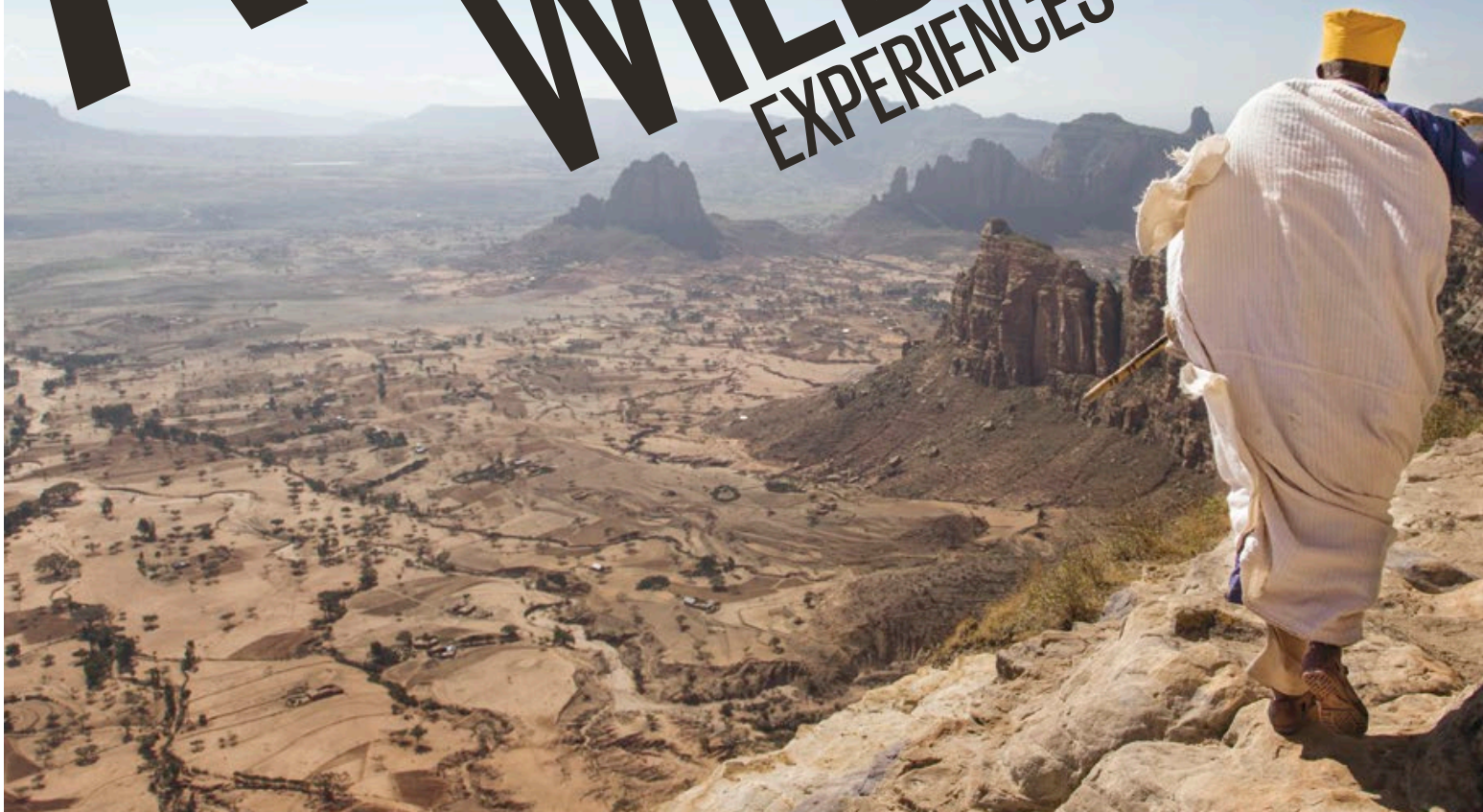
South Africa produces some of the planet's best palate-pleasing plonk and it would be criminal not to try a few drops. Lucky then, that **Wine Concepts** (11a; wineconcepts.co.za; 50 Kloof St) offers complimentary wine tasting six days a week (4-7pm Mon-Fri, noon-3pm Sat). **Tjing Tjing Rooftop Bar** (11b; tjingtjing.co.za; 165 Longmarket St) also offers free wine tasting from 5pm to 7pm on Wednesdays.

12 Cape Town Carnival

Born on Long St amid the orgy of euphoria and energy that surrounded SA's hosting of the 2010 Football World Cup, this carnival has since grown into a massive annual gathering to celebrate South Africa's diversity. Some 50,000 people watch and participate in festivities that engulf Green Point, with floats, music, dancing and after-partying. capetowncarnival.com; Fanwalk, Green Point; Mar; free.

Africa may be justifiably famous for its national parks, but some of the wildest experiences take place elsewhere. Push your boundaries with these unforgettable options.

AFRICA'S WILDEST EXPERIENCES





SURF SWELL IN LIBERIA

Ride some of the best breaks on the continent with a growing cast of Liberian surfers. The golden beaches stretch to the horizon, and at night the crashing waves glow with phosphorescence. Pack your surfboard! *Robert-sport, Liberia; free.*



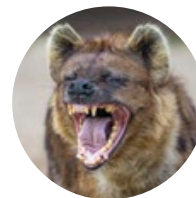
DUNE-WALK IN THE NAMIBIA

While huge swathes of the Namib's famous dunes sit within national parks, those just south of Swakopmund do not. Head out on the road to Walvis Bay and explore. Unique characteristics of the sand make some dunes hum as you walk along the crests. *Swakopmund, Namibia; free.*



SET EYES ON THE JADE SEA

The lake's eastern shore at the village of Loyangalani may be at the end of an incredibly long and uncomfortable transport-truck journey, but the volcanic landscapes, Jade Sea views and vibrant Turkana people are out of this world. *Lake Turkana, Kenya; free.*



HYENAS OF HARAR

The adventurous can take to the narrow alleys of Harar's old town at night to catch glimpses of the city's hyenas. Or shell out US\$2.50 and you can watch them being fed outside the 16th-century walls each evening – double it and you can feed them yourself... *Harar, Ethiopia; evenings; free.*



VISIT THE WORLD'S MOST DANGEROUS CHURCH

Carved into a sheer cliff face many centuries ago, the church of Abuna Yemata Guh requires visitors to climb a 6m-high vertical wall with no ropes and negotiate a narrow ledge over a 200m drop. Tips for local guides expected. *Abuna Yemata Guh, Tigray, Ethiopia; US\$7 plus tips.*



WILD FLOWERS OF NAMAKWA

The semi-desert of Namakwa erupts in a cornucopia of colour each spring when wildflowers carpet the landscape. Let's be clear, this is not a flower show or a larger-scale version of your granny's garden – it is one of Africa's most impressive sights. *Namakwa, South Africa; Aug-Sep; free.*



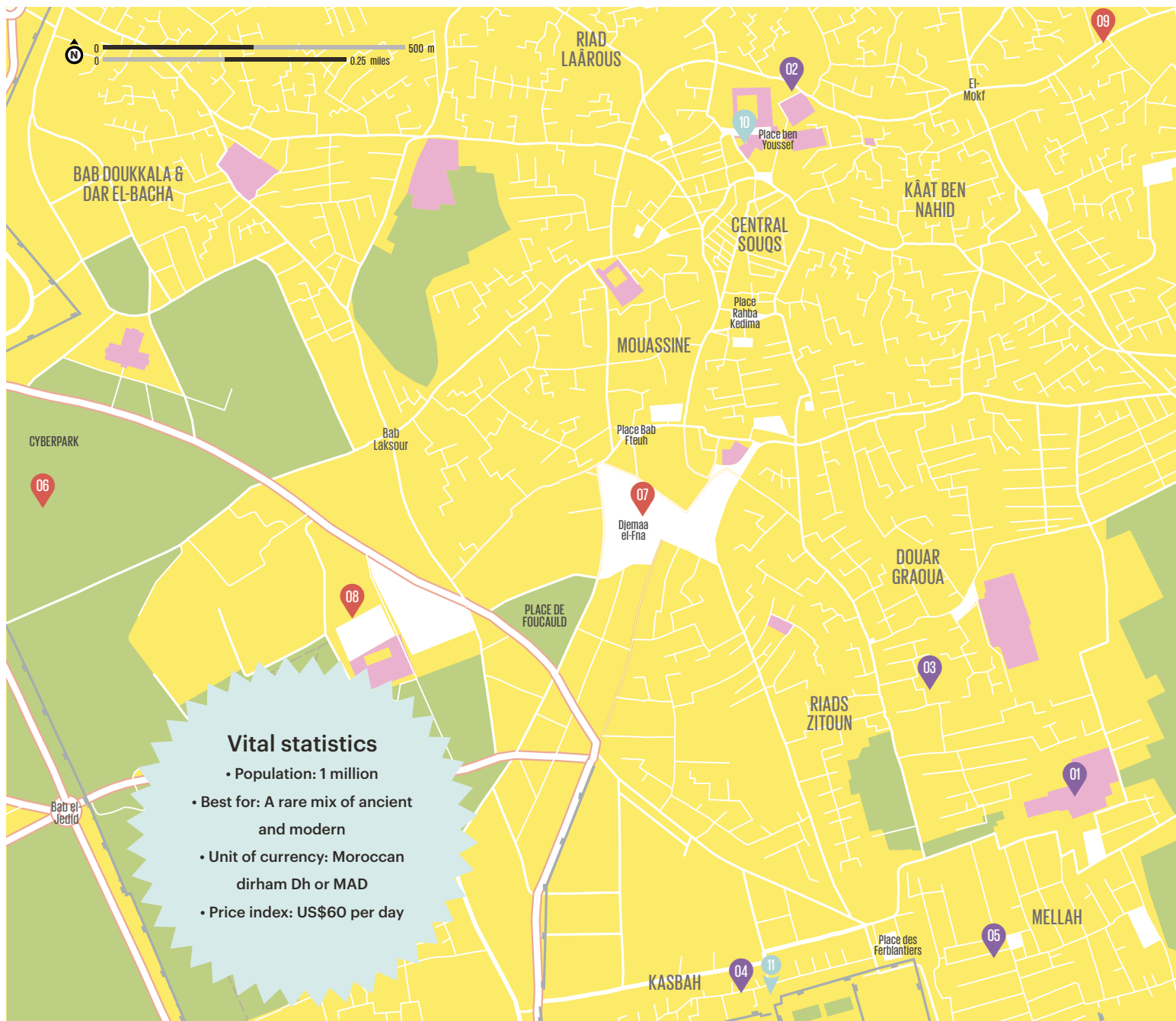
MARALAL INTERNATIONAL CAMEL DERBY

Join spectators to witness these epic cross-country camel races. Mingle with the crowds, attend the notorious parties and, if you're game, rent a camel and ride in the amateurs' race. www.kenyasafari.com/maralal-camel-derby.html; *Maralal, Kenya; free.*



TAKE A DIP IN DEVIL'S POOL

Drop into the Zambezi and swim in a natural pool on the edge of Victoria Falls while water slides past you and plummets over the 100m drop. Free it is not, but it's so wild it is worth the splurge (an incredible breakfast is included). tongabezi.com; *Livingstone Island, Victoria Falls, Zambia; May-Oct; US\$95.*



MARRAKESH

A trip to Marrakesh might conjure up images of the Rolling Stones buying up half the medina or A-listers partying in private suites at La Mamounia, but rest assured, this bustling, spicy, unforgettable city has plenty of attractions for mere mortals that don't demand you dish out all your dirhams.



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FOOD & DRINK



FESTIVALS & EVENTS

01 Bahia Palace

This somewhat dilapidated late-19th-century palace is exceptional value. Built over 15 years by Vizier Ahmed Ibn Moussa as a retreat for his harem, La Bahia ('Palace of the Beautiful') is a 160-room complex of intricately patterned rooms, polished cedar ceilings, cool marble and secluded courtyards, surrounded by 8 hectares of landscaped gardens. *Rue Riad Zitoun el-Jedid; 8.30-11.45am & 2.30-5.45pm Sat-Thu, 8.30-11.30am & 3-5.45pm Fri; Dh10.*

02 Dar Bellarj

The non-profit Dar Bellarj Foundation showcases Moroccan arts and crafts in this former 'stork hospital' (literally, a hospice for injured birds). Now one of the city's leading venues for material arts, it hosts changing exhibitions of weaving, painting and other genres. There are also kids' workshops in traditional Moroccan music, and concerts during Ramadan and the Ashura festival. *9-7 Toulate Zaouiate Lahdar; 9.30am-12.30pm & 2-5.30pm Mon-Sat; free.*

03 Dar Si Said

It's hard to know what's more impressive: the 1000-year-old collection of Moroccan and Berber artefacts or the Hispano-Moorish palace that houses them. Jewelled weapons, beaten-copper adornments, High Atlas carpets and lavish antique costumes are well worth the scant entrance fee, as is the domed wedding salon, faced with cedar intricately carved by *mââlems* (master artisans) from Fez. *Derb Si Said; 9am-4.45pm Wed-Mon; adult/child Dh10/3.*

04 Museum for Photography and Visual Arts (MMVPA)

The world's largest museum dedicated to photography and the visual arts is due to open opposite Menara Gardens in 2016; meanwhile, you can catch free exhibits in the temporary gallery in El Badi Palace. Giving a sense of what the finished museum will offer, the MMVPA focuses on images from Morocco and Northern Africa. *mmpva.org; Ksibat Nhass; 9am-5pm Wed-Mon; free.*

05 The Mellah

Marrakesh's 15th-century Jewish quarter is distinguished by its maze of *derbs* (alleys) and mud-brick buildings. No longer home to many Jews, their legacy survives in the **Lazama Synagogue** (*Derb Manchoura; tip expected*) and the *miaâra* or **Jewish cemetery** (*Ave Taoulat El Miara; tip expected*). Don't miss the **Mellah Market** (*Ave Houmane el-Fetouaki; 8am-1pm & 3-7pm; free*) and the artisans' showrooms around Pl des Ferblantiers.



ONE-DAY
FREE PASS

If your time is as limited as your budget, this mini-itinerary will give you a good day's sightseeing. Start your morning catching the current exhibition at the Dar Bellarj, then wend your way south-east through the Medina's maze of souqs until you reach Djemaa el-Fna (p016), the perfect spot for a snack and some snake charming. From here it's a short ramble south to the Jewish architecture of the Mellah. Finally, get some culture with your colossal camel burger at Café Clock (p017).





06 Cyber Park

You'll find these tranquil gardens – full name: the Arsat Moulay Abdeslam Cyber Park – not far from Djemaa el-Fna. Originally laid out by Prince Moulay as a market garden in the 18th century, it became an ornamental park in 1920. The 2005 redevelopment, combining lemon, olive and pomegranate trees, water features, neat paths and free wi-fi, pays homage to both antecedents. *morocco.com*; Ave Mohammed V; 9am-7pm; free.

07 Djemaa el-Fna

Djemaa el-Fna ('Assembly of the Dead') is Morocco's largest, best-known public square. It's listed by UNESCO for its Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity. Created as a site for public executions in AD 1050, it is now filled by day with snake charmers, magicians and orange juice vendors. At night, add street-food hawkers, musicians, storytellers, healers, dancers and pedlars. People-watching doesn't get any better. 9am-1am; free.



08 Koutoubia Mosque & Gardens

Koutoubia, built in the 12th century on the site of an earlier mosque imperfectly aligned with Mecca, is one of Marrakesh's great sights. The interior is off-limits to non-Muslims, but it can be appreciated externally. Its 70m-high minaret, topped with gleaming copper balls, is best viewed while strolling through the peaceful, palm-strewn gardens that surround it. *Cnr Rue el-Koutoubia & Ave Mohammed V*; gardens open 8am-8pm; free.



09 Tanneries

If you can stand the horrendous smell, then the outdoor tanneries are one of Marrakesh's classic free sights. The hides are treated in hundreds of concrete

MEDINA ETIQUETTE

Marrakesh has always been a mercantile metropolis: it pays to come prepared if you want to maximise your dirham. The hard sell is commonplace in the souqs, so be ready to stand your ground. Stallholders can be very forward, but are willing to haggle; just don't get involved in protracted negotiations if you don't plan to buy. You might also get the idea that guides are trying to edge you towards certain stalls: trust your instincts – of course they are! – and feel free to politely insist on looking further afield before committing to buying anything.



10

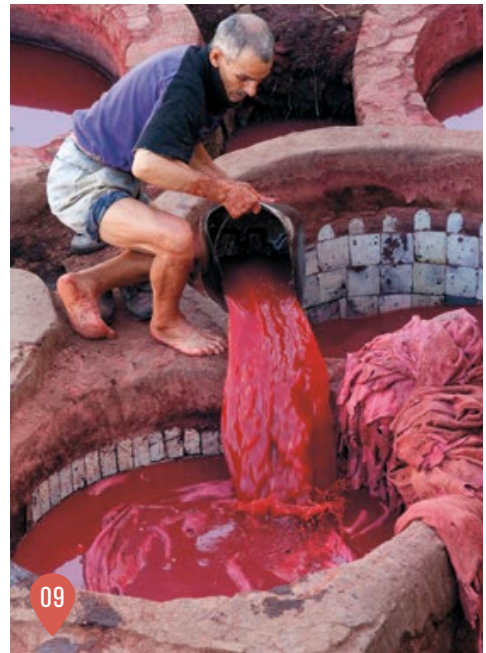
vats, following medieval techniques that involve quicklime, water, blood and even pigeon poo. Producing the many-hued leathers sold in the city's souqs is back-breaking, dirty work; sadly, now chemicals are also involved, it's unhealthy too. Ave Bab el-Debbagh; dawn-dusk; free.

10 Ben Youssef food stall qissaria

The food stalls in this *qissaria* (covered market) are often tiny operations where everything is done with skill and economy. They sell such unorthodox delights as snails, stewed sheep's head and grilled hearts, so be prepared. When you've sized up the offerings (including less challenging options like tagines, grilled meats and salads), grab a bench and eat al fresco. *Off Souq Shaaria, near Koubba Ba'adiyn; 11.30am-3.30pm; free.*

11 Café Clock

Moroccan tradition meets modern multimedia at this unique cafe. On Mondays, traditional storytellers practise their art (in English and Arabic),



09

Wednesdays are jam sessions open to anyone with an instrument, Saturdays are for guest artists and Sundays feature sunset concerts of hypnotic Gnawa music. There's also a constantly changing array of art on display, and the kitchen serves up a mean camel burger. *cafeclock.com; 224 Derb Chtouka; 10am-10pm; mains Dh55-80.*

12 Festival of Popular Arts

This midsummer festival lights up the streets of Marrakesh every July. International performers join Berber minstrels, Gnawa musicians, sword-swallowers, acrobats, dancers, snake charmers and street performers from across Morocco. Performances can be seen at outdoor venues across the city over the festival's 10 days, focused in the courtyards and gardens of the El Badi Palace, near Place des Ferblantiers. The extravaganza culminates in an intoxicating parade through Djemaa el-Fna. *morocco.com/theater/marrakech-popular-arts-festival; July; free.*

\$AFARI

WITHOUT THE BIG BUCKS

African safaris can cost upwards of US\$1000 per person per day, so here are some destinations where the wild rewards vastly outdo the price tag.

CYCLE SAFARI - KENYA

Beneath the basalt cliffs of this volcanic landscape are zebras, giraffes, impalas and other iconic species. Large carnivores are rare, however, so it's possible to spend a day walking or cycling; bikes can be rented nearby for an additional US\$6. Camping is available. kws.go.ke; Hell's Gate NP, Kenya; US\$30.

WEST AFRICAN SAFARI - GHANA

Known for its elephants, the savannah also hosts buffaloes, kob, baboons, warthogs and numerous bird species. Share the park's vehicle hire (US\$20 per hour) with others to make it more of a bargain. Budget accommodation too. molemotel-gh.com; Mole NP, Ghana; US\$8, plus guide US\$2.50/hr.

NAMIBIAN SAFARI - NAMIBIA

The desert-like environment around the massive Etosha salt pan is captivating, but it is the wildlife that frequents the waterholes here that make it one of Africa's best parks. Great roads mean small rental cars are an option, and camping is possible. etoshanationalpark.org; Etosha NP, Namibia; US\$7.



BIG FIVE SAFARI – SOUTH AFRICA

Kruger is one of the world's greatest parks – the Big Five are all here, along with an extensive cast of other safari species. Independent access is a breeze, camping options are plentiful and there are 19,485 sq km of incredible landscapes. sanparks.org; Kruger NP, South Africa; US\$20.

WALKING SAFARI – TANZANIA

Think of a thousand hippos sharing a mud bath and you're on the right track. The park comes to life in dry season (August to October). Camp in nearby Sitalike and share the armed guide fee (US\$20 per group). tanzaniaparks.com; Katavi NP, Tanzania; US\$80 (including walking permit).

OKAVANGO DELTA MOKORO SAFARI – BOTSWANA

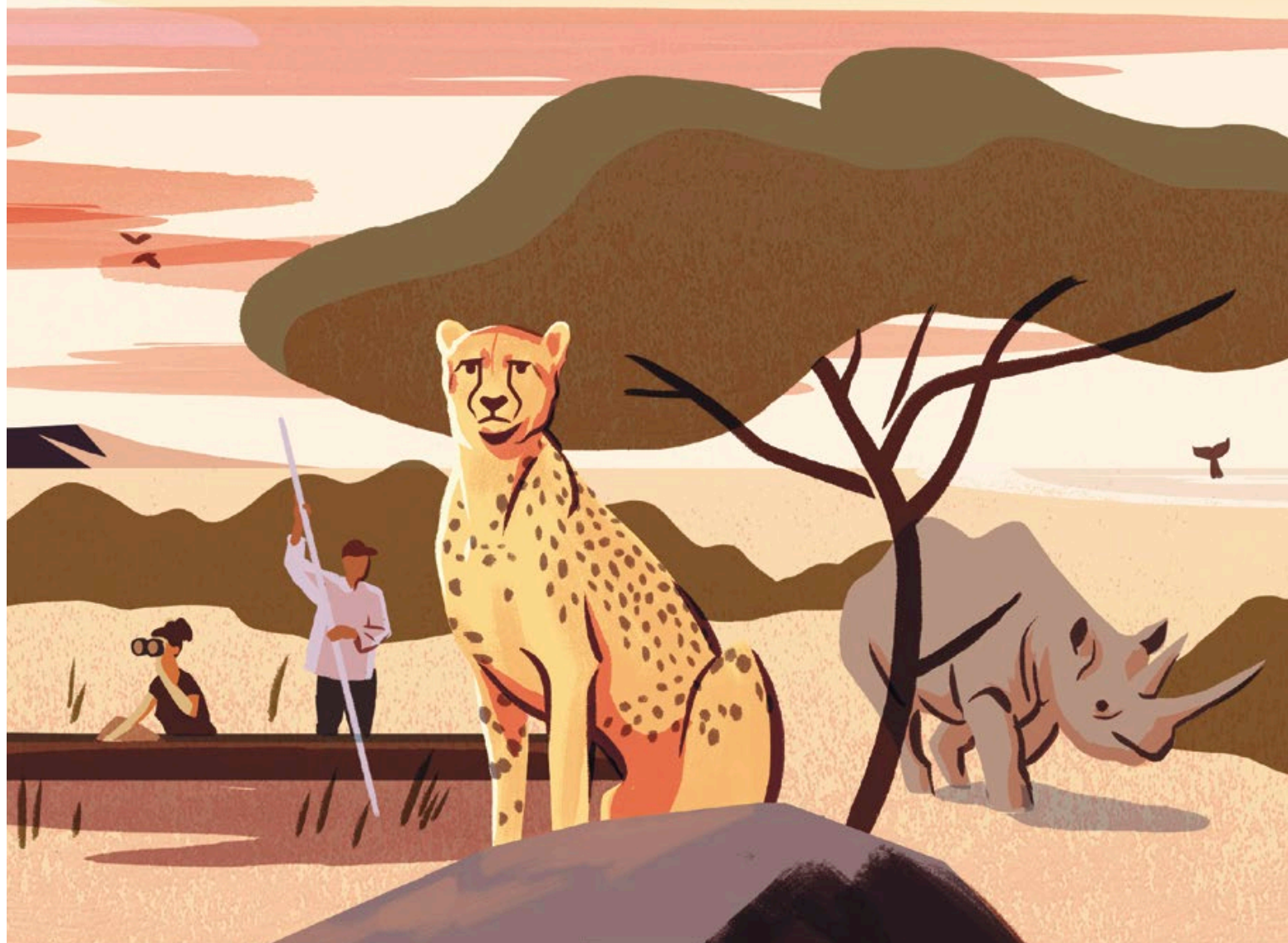
Being poled through the Okavango Delta in a dugout canoe is one of Africa's greatest, and most expensive, experiences. However, Old Bridge Backpackers offer self-catered camping options ranging from US\$70 (one day) to US\$140 (four days). maun-backpackers.com; Old Bridge Backpackers, Maun, Botswana; from US\$70.

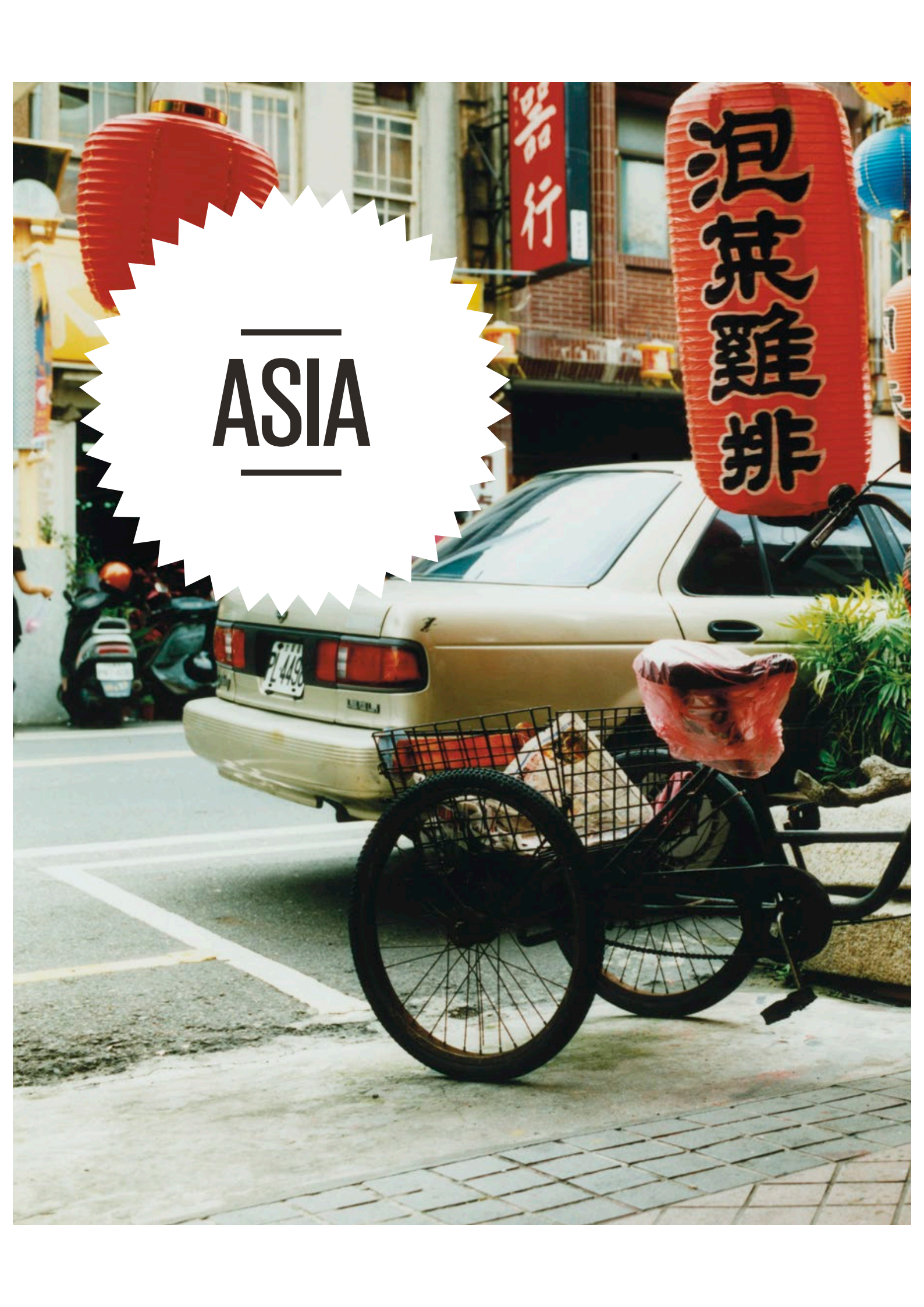
WEST AFRICAN SAFARI

The coastal town of St Lucia is on the doorstep of two great parks: iSimangaliso (isimangaliso.com) and Hluhluwe-iMfolozi (hluhluwegamereserve.com). The latter is a classic Big Five destination, while the former hosts both land animals and aquatic ones. Budget safaris and accommodation available. St Lucia, KwaZulu-Natal, South Africa; from US\$40.

TRACKING GORILLAS – UGANDA

The value of sharing a glance with a gorilla in the wild is something that can't be quantified. Visit Bwindi during low season (April, May and November) and permits are US\$350 instead of US\$600. Permits in Rwanda are US\$750. ugandawildlife.org; Bwindi Impenetrable NP, Uganda; from US\$350.



A photograph of a street scene in Asia. In the foreground, a black bicycle with a wire basket is parked on a paved sidewalk. The basket contains some items, including a red plastic bag. Behind the bicycle, a white sedan is parked. In the background, there are buildings with red lanterns hanging from them. One large red lantern has the Chinese characters "泡菜雞排" (Pickled Cabbage Chicken Cutlet) written on it. Another red lantern has the characters "器行" (Tool Shop) written on it. The word "ASIA" is overlaid in the center of the image, with horizontal lines above and below it.

ASIA



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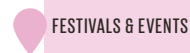
MUSIC & FILM



SPORTS & LEISURE



FOOD & DRINK



FESTIVALS & EVENTS

01 Baan Silapin Artist's House

Hidden away on a Thonburi *klorn*g (canal), this historic wooden house is home to traditional puppeteers, who are training the next generation in this ancient Southeast Asian art form. Every afternoon from 2pm the black-clad puppetmasters bring Thai legends to life; it's nostalgic and atmospheric. *Wat Thong Sala Ngam, Soi 28, Th Phet Kasem; 10am-6pm; free.*

02 The Bangkokian Museum

The pocket-sized Bangkokian is a hidden jewel in a city where most of the treasures are proudly on display. Spread over a series of dolls' house-like homes are rooms full of personal belongings that look as if the owners stepped through the front door to pick up some noodles in 1960 and never came back. *273 Soi 43, Th Charoen Krung; 10am-4pm Wed-Sun; free.*

03 Wat Arun

The small entrance fee at Wat Arun delivers priceless experiences. Approached from the river, the towering *prangs* (Khmer-style towers) of the Temple of Dawn look like carved stone; up close, they reveal themselves to be gardens of mosaic flowers in broken Chinese porcelain. Dip your head respectfully to the *yaksha* (guardian giants) as you enter the statue-filled gardens. *watarun.net; off Th Arun Amarin; 8am-6pm; 50B.*

04 Aerobics at Saranrom Park

After a few seafood feasts, many visitors to Bangkok feel like they might benefit from a little exercise. Why delay? Every evening, Saranrom Park fills with

the sound of grunts and pop beats as free open-air aerobics classes roll into motion. All welcome; leotards optional. *Bounded by Th Ratchini, Th Charoen Krung & Th Sanam Chai; park open 5am-9pm; free.*

05 Ban Baat

Thailand's monks need freight-loads of begging bowls (*bàht*) for collecting alms for the poor, and this tiny urban village keeps the traditional bowl-making art alive. Jump off the *klorn*g boat at Tha Phan Fah and you'll hear the tap, tap, tap of metalworkers hammering bowls together from eight leaves of different metals, representing the eightfold path of Buddhism. *Soi Ban Baat; 8am-5pm; free.*

06 Chao Phraya Express Ferry

For about the price of a bowl of rice, you can board Bangkok's most atmospheric vantage point on a budget river cruise. The best time to ride the ferry is at dusk; join the monks waiting at Tha Phra Athit pier and cruise past some of Krung Thep's landmark monuments, refreshed by balmy evening breezes. *chaophrayaexpressboat.com; Th Phra Athit Pier; 9.30am-10pm; 10-40B.*

07 Golden Mount (Wat Saket)

Low-rise Ko Ratanakosin and Banglamphu are big on bucket lists but short on viewpoints from where they can be seen. That's where the Golden Mount comes in. Just east of the Democracy Monument, this artificial mountain is crowned by a looming golden *chedi* terrace and offers bird's-eye city views. *Off Th Boriphat; 7.30am-5.30pm; free.*

MASSAGE
ON THE
CHEAP

Massage is part of the culture in Bangkok, but finding a legitimate budget massage among the pricey spas and dodgy operators can be something of a challenge. Our tip is head to source – Wat Pho (*Th Sanam Chai; 8.30am-6.30pm*) is both an astonishing temple and the spiritual home of Thai massage and traditional Thai medicine. At the famous massage school you can get a relaxing 30-minute pummelling from monastery-trained practitioners in one of the pavilions within the temple or in the training facility without, all for a wallet-pleasing 260B.





BOOZE AND DON'TS

Exploring Bangkok can be thirsty work, but a bottle of Chang beer can cost more than a meal, and wine and spirits can empty your wallet in a heartbeat. Follow the lead of locals and stock up on refreshments at the nearest 7-Eleven, saving posh sit-down drinks for special occasions. Your hotel balcony is the best spot for an impromptu drinks party; public drinking is frowned upon, and banned in parks and religious sites, including the grounds of monasteries.



08 Ko Kret Island

Bangkok's tiny Burmese enclave feels like a country village, smuggled into the northern suburbs and secreted inside a loop of the Chao Phraya River. Founded in 1722, this miniature community of potters follows an 18th-century pace of life. Wander boardwalk lanes past potters' studios to a tiny, wonky riverside *chedi* in the Mon style. At weekends there's a bustling (rather unpleasantly so) market. *Nonthaburi; 24hr; free.*

09 Lumphini Park

Before Bangkok erupts into life each morning, a more gentle awakening takes place in Lumphini Park, where old-timers gather to practise t'ai-chi before an audience of monitor lizards and the odd jogging octogenarian. For a few precious hours the city seems to float in a bubble of calm, before revving engines break the illusion. *Bounded by Th Sarasin, Th Phra Ram IV, Th Witthayu & Th Ratchadamri; 4.30am-9pm, free.*

10 MBK Center Moo-ay tai

Moo-ay tai (Thai boxing) is a sport for connoisseurs, which may explain the steep price tags that accompany tickets at the stadiums. No matter: boxing fans on a budget can get in on the action for free every Wednesday at 6pm, when boisterous bouts fill an open-air ring in front of Bangkok's favourite teen fashion mall. *Th Rama I; from 6pm Wed; free.*

11 Pak Khlong Talat Flower Market

Flowers aren't just for special occasions here; locals sweeten the air with perfumed blooms as part of their daily routine. At festivals and celebrations, though, flower-arranging goes into overdrive, with outrageous floats of flowers and banana leaves for processions

ONE-DAY FREE PASS

Start off the day by taking a 7am meditation class at Wat Mahathat; you'll need that sense of inner calm as you navigate the backpacker crowds to reach Tha Phra Athit pier, embarkation point for the Chao Phraya Express Ferry (p023). Ride the river on to Tha Ratchawong pier, then stroll up to Tha Yaowarat in Chinatown for lunch. It's only a short hop north to the lanes of Ban Baat (p023), then watch the sunset on top of the Golden Mount (p023). Suitably uplifted, wander across the *klorng* for a bowl of the city's best *pât tai* at Thip Samai.



and home shrines. If nothing else, the market has to be the most fragrant spot in the city. *Th Chakraphet*; 24hr; free.

12 Wat Mahathat meditation classes

While the crowds mob the cloisters of Wat Pho, you'll find a little Buddhist serenity nearby at Wat Mahathat, where local worshippers outnumber selfie-takers and tour guides. Three-hour meditation classes run daily by donation, and the *wí-hăhn* (main chapel) is ringed by shady Buddha-filled cloisters so you can find space for inner reflection. 3 *Th Maha Rat*; meditation classes 7am, 1pm & 6pm; free.

13 Chinatown street eats

Everyone knows the best food in Bangkok is served up on the street, and Chinatown is the top table in town. On the *sois* (side streets) along *Tha Yaowarat*, slippery noodles coil like snakes, fish swim in rivers of sweet chilli, prawns dive into sizzling sauces and crabs caper in curry seas. It's Bangkok's tastiest, most diverse street-food feast at bargain prices. Happy eating! *bangkok.com/chinatown*; *Th Yaowarat*; 5-11pm; dishes 30-50B.

14 Thip Samai

Forget the insipid, greasy *pât tai* sold on *Tha Khao San*; people in the know make a beeline for Thip Samai to consume bowl after bowl of 'Ghost Gate Noodles' – the best *pât tai* in Bangkok, and by extension, the world. Thip Sami is low-key, local and delicious, as the queues attest. 313 *Th Mahachai*; 5.30pm-1.30am, closed on alternate Wed; mains 25-120B.

15 Victory Monument boat noodles

Most of the soup vendors who used to ply their trade along Bangkok's *klorng* have long since hung up their paddles, but you can still find the delicious 'boat

noodle soup' that made them famous on a narrow alleyway north of the Victory Monument, at prices so low locals order three bowls at one sitting. Off *Th Phaholyothin*, Victory Monument; 11am-6pm; noodle soup from 11B.

16 Amulet Market

Thai Buddhists have been trading religious amulets for centuries. Collectors congregate at the amulet-stacked stands that dot the pavement along *Tha Maha Rat*, haggling over particularly sought-after Buddhist tablets, votive objects and oversized phallic symbols. Look out for committed aficionados, struggling to stand under the weight of all their amulets. *Th Maha Rat*; 7am-5pm; free.

17 Chatuchak Weekend Market

Leaving practically every other market in Thailand in the shade, Chatuchak is not so much a market as a city of stalls. In this maze of alleyways, you can haggle for antique lacquerware, bargain for chopsticks, negotiate for Thai silk and hill-tribe silver, or just sip cocktails in a back-alley bar watching the mayhem unfold. Weekends were made for this! *chatuchak.org*; *Th Phahonyothin*; 9am-6pm Sat + Sun; admission free.

18 Rot Fai Market

An abandoned rail yard seems just the right setting for a market devoted to everything retro. Stalls at Rot Fai are stacked high with pre-loved biker jackets, vintage Vespas and mid-century Bakelite and melamine. Mobile bars in flip-top VW campers and armies of young Thai hipsters stocking up on retro threads just add to the carnival atmosphere. *facebook.com/taradrodfi*; *Soi 51, Th Srinakharin*; 6pm-midnight Wed & Fri-Sun; admission free.